

The Mouse Trap

Here are 10 entrants in the mice race. May the best mouse win!

The two-button scroll mouse is still the best seller today. Optical mice from vendors such as Mercury and The Best can be bought for anywhere between Rs 700 and Rs 1,000. While they are more affordable, mass acceptance is still another price cut away, especially when a normal ball mouse can be had for less than Rs 400. The professional user would, of course, like the reduced hassle and the greater accuracy afforded by the optical devices. We test 10 mice that cover both the ball and the optical variety, and come with and without cords.

Digit Test Process

We tested the mice on a system with a Pentium 4 2.2 GHz processor, an MSI MAX2BLR motherboard, 256 MB DDRRAM and a 40 GB Seagate Barracuda drive running Windows XP Professional. Four primary parameters were marked: features, ergonomics, build quality and value for money. Each parameter was allotted a 25 per cent weightage. The weightages allotted to each parameter was used to calculate the overall scores.

Features: The primary feature tested was the accuracy a mouse provided in gaming and image editing. the devices were rated on a scale of five. Next, we noted the extra programmable buttons that increase productivity. A mouse that supported the USB interface obviously scored more than one designed for the PS/2 port. Similarly, an optical mouse was rated higher than a ball mouse. As a final point of comparison, the length of the cable was also considered—the longer the tail, the more the mouse scored.

Ergonomics: A mouse was rated on a scale of five based on the degree of symmetry that it afforded to a user—both right and left handed. Next on the agenda was the grip, both on a surface and with the palm. A mouse that presented better traction and palm grip scored higher on a scale of five. To judge the ease of use, we rated each mouse on the placement of buttons and design aspects that allowed them to sit snugly within the palm.

Build quality: To test the build quality we dropped the mouse from a height of 6 feet. We then noticed any physical damage, following which the mouse was re-attached to the PC to ensure a working condition. Also tested was the quality and stability of the buttons that form the pointing device.

P R O D U C T S	
FRONTECH JIL-7001	
FRONTECH JU-830	
IBALL THE KING	
LOGITECH CORDLESS MOUSEMAN OPTICAL	
LOGITECH MOUSEMAN DUAL OPTICAL	
MERCURY OPTICAL SCROLL MOUSE	
MICROSOFT TRACKBALL OPTICAL	
MICROSOFT WIRELESS INTELLIMOUSE EXPLORER	
ODYSSEY WEB SCROLL MOUSE	
SAMSUNG SMP 2100WX	

Frontech JIL-7001

Features: PS/2 interface, no extra buttons Price: Rs 200
Contact: Jupiter Infosys India Ltd Phone: 022-22001211
E-mail: frontech@bom5.vsnl.net.in Web site: www.frontech.com

The JIL-7001 from Frontech combines a metallic dark blue with silver with stunning effects. This makes the device stand out from the crowd of the regular two-button scroll mice.



This Plug and Play mouse does not require any drivers to get it up and running. A PS/2 connectivity, however, takes away from hot plugging the device. Gamers used to the two-button mouse will find this mouse suitable to their need as there is no design difference. This mouse is available for just Rs 200, hence making it the cheapest of the lot and given its performance in different applications, this is a good buy.

Frontech JIL-7001		B+
Features	▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶	

Frontech JU-830

Features: USB interface, two extra buttons Price: Rs 350
Contact: Jupiter Infosys India Ltd Phone: 022-22001211
E-mail: frontech@bom5.vsnl.net.in Web site: www.frontech.com

The JU-830 is a two-button scroll mouse, with two extra buttons on the sides. Upon installation of the supplied drives, these buttons can be programmed to certain actions that include simulating mouse actions such as a double-click, zooming in on Web pages, or mapping keyboard keys like [F1], [Page Up], etc. The extra buttons take a little getting used to, especially if you've assigned them functions. Often, these buttons get pressed while moving the mouse around. The device uses a PS/2 interface to connect to the computer, and has a resolution of 400 dpi, both of which are very standard features. The mouse on the whole is very ordinary, and at Rs 350, it does not pretend otherwise.



Frontech JU-830		A-
Features	▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶	